4 The Secret Garden

Warm up

Shut your eyes for a moment and think of a place that is very special to you. Write down any five things you like about that place, and take turns in class to share what your special places are.

Ten-year-old Mary Lennox moved from India to England to live at her uncle's house after her parents passed away. The house was close to the woods and had a large garden. When her uncle was away on business, Mary found a key buried in the garden. After a few days of searching, she realized that the key unlocked a door hidden by ivy creepers at the end of the garden. The door led to another little garden that had been planted by her late aunt. Mary learnt that after her aunt had passed away ten years ago, her grief-stricken uncle had locked up the garden. Ever since, no one went into the garden—not even Ben, the elderly gardener. The garden slowly withered away with time. Mary decided to bring the garden to life, and asked Martha, the housekeeper, for garden tools. Martha promised to send them with Dickon, her twelve-year-old brother.

Let's read more about Mary and her special place.

Mary called her special place the 'secret garden'. Determined to bring the garden to life, she secretly worked there every day. It seemed almost like being shut out of the world in some fairy place. Every sprouting, new shoot gave her hope.

Mary started spending time with Ben to learn more about gardening. She no longer spoke haughtily to him.

ivy creepers: a type of climbing plant with dark green, five-pointed leaves
grief-stricken: feeling extremely sad because of something that has happened, especially the death of somebody
withered: dried up
sprouting: starting to grow
haughtily: arrogantly

"You're starting to be a hard worker," he said to her one day. "You're not so thin and pale as you were before. You were frail as a dragonfly's wing when you first came here," he recalled. Ben was right. Ever since Mary started spending time outdoors in the secret garden, her health improved. She could run faster and longer now, and even skip to a hundred!

One morning, Mary heard a whistling sound coming from over the garden wall. She followed the sound into the woods. What she saw took her breath away! Sitting under a tree was a boy with rust-coloured hair, playing a wooden pipe. His cheeks were as red as poppies, and he had the bluest eyes Mary had ever seen. A squirrel was clinging to the tree just over his shoulder, watching him. A pheasant was hiding behind a small bush and was stretching its neck to peek out at him. Two rabbits sat nearby, twitching their noses as if they had come to a concert.

When the boy spotted Mary, he held up his hand. He warned in a low voice, "Don't move! It would frighten them." He stopped playing and stood up very slowly—almost like he wasn't moving at all. When he finally got to his feet, the animals scampered away. They didn't seem afraid.

Which phrase in the story is used to express a mix of admiration and great surprise?

"I'm Dickon," the boy said, "and you must be Mary. I've brought the garden tools." He showed her a package wrapped in brown paper. "There's a spade, a rake, a fork and a hoe. There is a trowel too, and some flower seeds," he added. They sat on a log, and Dickon explained how to plant the seeds.

Suddenly, they heard a chirping sound coming from a holly bush. "There's a robin calling someone he's friends with," Dickon said.

"He's seen me in the garden. I think he knows me a little," Mary answered.

frail: weak recalled: remembered clinging: holding tightly pheasant: a kind of a large bird with a long tail twitching: making a small, sudden movement scampered: moved with quick, light steps rake: a garden tool with a handle and a row of metal points, used for gathering fallen leaves fork: a garden tool with four sharp points attached to a handle, used for digging hoe: a tool with a thin metal blade attached to a long handle, used for breaking up soil and removing weeds trowel: a small tool with a handle and curved metal blade, used for digging holes and lifting plants holly bush: a bush with pointed leaves and bright red berries

Dickon quietly moved close to the bush. He made a sound like the robin's own twitter. The robin listened curiously and answered quite as if he were replying to a question. Mary was amazed. "Do you really understand everything birds say?" she asked. Dickon grinned. "I think so," he said, "I've lived on the moor for so long that I feel I'm one of them. Sometimes I think I'm a bird or a fox." Then, he asked, "Where is your garden? I can help you sow some seeds."

How does the author show us that Dickon has lived on the moor all his life?

Mary turned pale. She twisted her hands in her lap and looked at the ground. Dickon was puzzled. He asked, "You do have one, don't you?" Mary said nothing for several minutes.

Then, she looked up and said, "Can you keep a secret if I told you one? If anyone finds out, I think I might be in trouble!"

Dickon felt more puzzled than ever, but he said, "I keep secrets from other lads all the time—secrets about foxes' cubs, birds' nests and wild burrows, so that no one bothers them on the moor. I'll keep your secret too."

Mary rose from the log at once and revealed, "I've discovered a garden that was locked away ten years ago. Even Ben doesn't go in there. Come! I'll show you." Dickon followed Mary as she led him to the wall where the ivy grew thickly. She found the door, unlocked it, and led him inside. "It's a secret garden," she said, "They're letting it die—but I want it to live!"

Dickon took his first look around. He said in a curious whisper, "It's a strange, pretty place. It's like we're in a dream!"

For two or three minutes, he stood looking round him. Then, he began to walk about softly, taking in everything—the grey trees with the grey creepers climbing over them and hanging from their branches, the tangle on the walls and among the grass, the stone seats and tall flower urns.

Why do you think the author has used the colour 'grey' to describe the trees and creepers in the secret garden?

twitter: a chirping sound moor: a high, open area of land covered with rough grass revealed: disclosed
tangle: twisted bundle of something that cannot be easily separated urns: tall, decorated containers

"What do you think? Will there be roses?" she whispered, "Can you tell? I thought perhaps they were all dead."

"Eh! No, not all of them!" he answered, "There's a lot of dead wood that ought to be cut out, but there's also some living ones at places. Look, here's a new bit," he said as he touched a shoot which looked brownish green instead of hard, dry grey.

Mary touched it eagerly and asked, "It's quite alive, isn't it?"

Dickon smiled widely and said, "It's as wick as you or me." Mary remembered that Martha had told her that 'wick' meant 'alive' or 'lively'. "I'm glad it's wick!" she cried out in her whisper.

They went from bush to bush and from tree to tree. Dickon cleared the dead wood using the tools he had brought. He taught her how to spot the boughs or twigs that still had life in them. He dug about roots with the spade and showed her how to stir the earth using a fork, to let the air in. "There's a lot of work to do here!" he said, looking about deep in thought.

"Will you come again and help me?" Mary requested, "Oh! Please do come, Dickon!"

"I'll come every day, rain or shine," he answered eagerly. "It's the most fun I ever had in my life—shut in here and waking up in a garden."

He began to walk about, looking up at the trees and bushes with a thoughtful expression. He said, "I don't want to make it look like a gardener's garden, all clipped and spick and span. It's nicer like this with things running wild." Mary nodded in agreement.

Which expression in the story means 'neat and clean'?

Mary was startled when she heard the big clock in the courtyard strike the hour of her midday dinner. "I shall have to go," she said mournfully. She bid him goodbye and turned to leave. Then, she stopped midway and asked, "Whatever happens, you ... you won't ever tell anyone about the secret garden, will you?"

Dickon smiled. "If you were a missel thrush and you showed me where your nest was, do you think I'd tell anyone?" he said, "Your secret garden is as safe as a missel thrush's nest."

And Mary was quite sure it was.

adapted from *The Secret Garden*

ought to: used to say the right thing to do boughs: large branches of a tree twigs: small, thin branches of a tree
rain or shine: no matter what happens clipped: cut with scissors or shears to make something neater
startled: surprised mournfully: sorrowfully missel thrush: a kind of a large bird with spots on its front

Frances Hodgson Burnett (1849-1924) was an English-American author and playwright. She was best known for her children's novels *Little Lord Fauntleroy*, *A Little Princess* and *The Secret Garden*. This extract has been taken from *The Secret Garden* which was first published in 1911. The novel explores how nature and friendship can bring us happiness.

Make connections

In this section, we will:
- learn to differentiate between round and flat characters using evidence from the story.
- remember details about the story.

(C-2.1, C-2.2)

Map the story

Much like people in real life, characters sometimes undergo a change as a story progresses.

Characters with a complex, layered personality are called round characters.

Characters which are relatively simpler and remain the same throughout a story are called flat characters.

Mary is an excellent example of a round character. The second paragraph of the story describes changes in Mary before and after she discovered the secret garden. Follow the example given below and list these changes.

Before	After
1. Mary did not know much about gardening.	She learnt a lot more about gardening from Ben.
2.	
3.	
4.	
5.	

Deep dive

Answer the following questions with reference to context.

1. *"There is a robin calling someone he's friends with," Dickon said. ... Dickon quietly moved close to the bush. He made a sound like the robin's own twitter. The robin listened curiously and answered quite as if he were replying to a question.*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Which friend do you think was the robin calling?	b. Birds tend to fly away when humans move close to them. Why do you think the robin trusted Dickon?	c. Write a few lines about a similar friendly interaction you have had with a bird or an animal.

2. *"If you were a missel thrush and you showed me where your nest was, do you think I'd tell anyone?" he said, "Your secret garden is as safe as a missel thrush's nest."*

RECALL	INFER	ANALYSE
a. Who was reassuring whom in these lines and why?	b. What has the secret garden been compared to in these lines? How are they similar?	c. If you were the listener, would you trust Dickon with a secret? Give reasons behind your answer.

Read, reflect and write

1. How does the writer show us that the secret garden is a special place for Mary? Cite examples from the story.
2. Read this line from the story: "*It's a strange, pretty place. It's like we're in a dream!*" Imagine that you are Dickon, and you are looking at the secret garden for the very first time. What do you see that is 'strange' and 'pretty'? Why do you think the place feels dreamlike?
3. Working in the secret garden made Mary feel happier and helped her through a difficult time. Briefly describe an activity (or activities) that bring you joy.

Integrate

Think of a garden or park that you would like to have in your neighbourhood. Draw a labelled design or map of it. Include at least five local trees or shrubs in your plan. List how it would benefit the community.

In this section, we will:
- unscramble words to name insects using picture clues.
- identify and use the correct relation word based on a given context.

(C-4.2)

Word wall

Interesting insects

Birds, rabbits and squirrels are garden creatures, and so are insects. Use the picture clues to unscramble the letters to get the names of a few insects.

1. A _____ (YRBLIADD) can eat up to 5000 other bugs in its lifetime!

2. A _____ (NODFRALGY) can hover in mid-air, and fly right, left, upwards, downwards, forwards and even backwards.

3. A _____ (TELBEE) consumes dead wood.

4. A _____ (RANIGYP NISTAM) can look over its shoulder.

5. A _____ (TOHM) is a nocturnal creature—it is most active at night.

6. A _____ (FRILEFY) uses its light to communicate with other members of its species.

7. A _____ (KSICT CETINS) gets its name because it is very good at camouflaging like twigs. ('Camouflaging' means hiding yourself by looking like the things around you and blending into the surroundings to avoid predators.)

Relation words: People we know

Dickon was Mary's ally. An ally is someone who helps and supports a person in a difficult situation.

Let's look at a few more relation words. Choose the appropriate relation word from the box to fill in the blanks.

sidekick	ancestors	pen pal	rivals
mentor	patron	competitors	coworkers

1. Our human _____ most likely date back to around 30,15,000 years.
2. Although the leaders are old _____, they are now working together for climate action.
3. Bees are excellent _____. They work together in a hive to make honey.
4. Deepika Kumari defeated her _____ and won the gold medal in archery at the 2010 Commonwealth Games.
5. I have received a letter from my _____ in Australia.
6. The King Krishnadevaraya was a great _____ of arts and literature, encouraging many artists and poets.
7. In *The Jungle Book*, Baloo the bear was Mowgli's _____—a buddy who shared his adventures.
8. Sachin Tendulkar has been a _____ to many young cricketers, guiding them to be their best.

Grammar time

In this section, we will:
- learn how to identify and use the present and the past perfect tense. (C-3.4)

Present perfect tense

Read the given sentences.

- Mary has come all the way from India.
- The rose bushes have dried up.

In these sentences, *has come* and *have dried up* are verbs.
They are in the present perfect tense.

The present perfect tense refers to an action that **was completed** or **perfected** in the past, and still has an effect in the present.

Read the table below to see how we use the present perfect tense.

Usage	Examples
for an action that has just happened	I have just read a story written by Frances Hodgson Burnett. Dickon has just arrived.
for an experience	Our teacher has read many books. I have travelled by train.
to show a change	I have finished my work. (I had not finished it earlier, but now I have.) The paint on my picture has dried. (It was wet a while ago. Now, it is not wet anymore.)
for an action that started in the past and still continues	I have studied in this school for five years. (I came to this school five years ago and I am still here.)

We use the form: *has/have* + past participle form of the main verb

Let us read these sentences aloud to practise the structure of a sentence in the present perfect tense.

Noun/pronoun	Auxiliary or helping verb		Main verb	
I	have		painted	a lot of pictures.
You	have		won	the match!
She/He	has	not	read	this book.
We	have	not	been	to France.

Auxiliary or helping verb	Noun/pronoun		Main verb	
Have	you		won	the match?
Has	she/he	not	read	the book?

Verbs have more than one form. For the present perfect tense, we use the *past participle* form of the main verb.

In most cases, the past participle form is the same as the past form. However, in a few cases, the past participle form is different from the past form. In some other cases, the past participle form and the past form are the same as the base form.

Base form of the verb	Past form of the verb	Past participle form of the verb
create	created	created
decide	decided	decided
eat	ate	eaten
choose	chose	chosen
shut	shut	shut
read	read	read

Fill in the blanks using the present perfect forms of the verbs given in the brackets.

1. My grandparents _____ just _____. (arrive).
2. I cannot play this weekend because I _____ (hurt) my leg.
3. We _____ (live) in this house for ten years.
4. Akshu _____ not _____ (meet) my friends yet. I will introduce them to her.
5. _____ he _____ (complete) the project?

Past perfect tense

Read the given sentence.

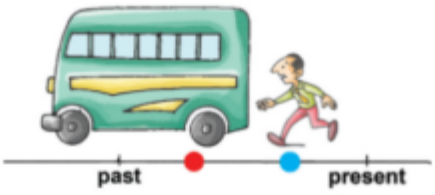
- Dickon had completed the song by the time Mary arrived.

In this sentence, *had completed* and *arrived* are verbs. Both verbs are in the past, but *had completed* is in the past perfect tense because Dickon had completed the song before Mary arrived.

When two actions happen in the past and we want to show which action happened **first**, we use the past perfect tense.

Read the given sentences.

- The bus had left by the time he reached.



- We had planted the trees when the rain started.

We use the form: *had* + past participle form of the main verb

Let us read these sentences aloud to practise the structure of the past perfect tense.

	Auxiliary or helping verb		Main verb	
I	had		read	the book that he gave me.
He	had		made	dinner before the guests arrived.
They	had		practised	before the match started.
We	had	not	seen	him before he came here.

1. In the sentences given below, underline the action that happened first.

a. When I woke up this morning, my brother had made breakfast.

b. The dog had torn the newspaper before Grandmother could read it.

c. The train had pulled out of the station by the time we reached the platform.

d. I had finished my homework when my friends arrived.

2. Be the perfect detective! Circle the mistakes in the past perfect tense of the following sentences and correct them.

a. I have ate a lot of cookies.

b. He didn't come with us to watch the film because he had already saw it.

c. We have just finish our work.

d. As soon as she had did her homework, she went to bed.

e. Tom was thirsty because he hadn't drink water all morning.

Pronunciation

/w/ and /v/ sound words

In this section, we will:
- learn to correctly pronounce words starting with /w/ and /v/ sounds (C-1.1)

Read the words on the next page aloud. Make sure your lips form a rounded *o* when you say the words that begin with *w*. When you say the words that begin with *v*, remember to lightly bite your lower lip with your upper teeth to get the right sound.

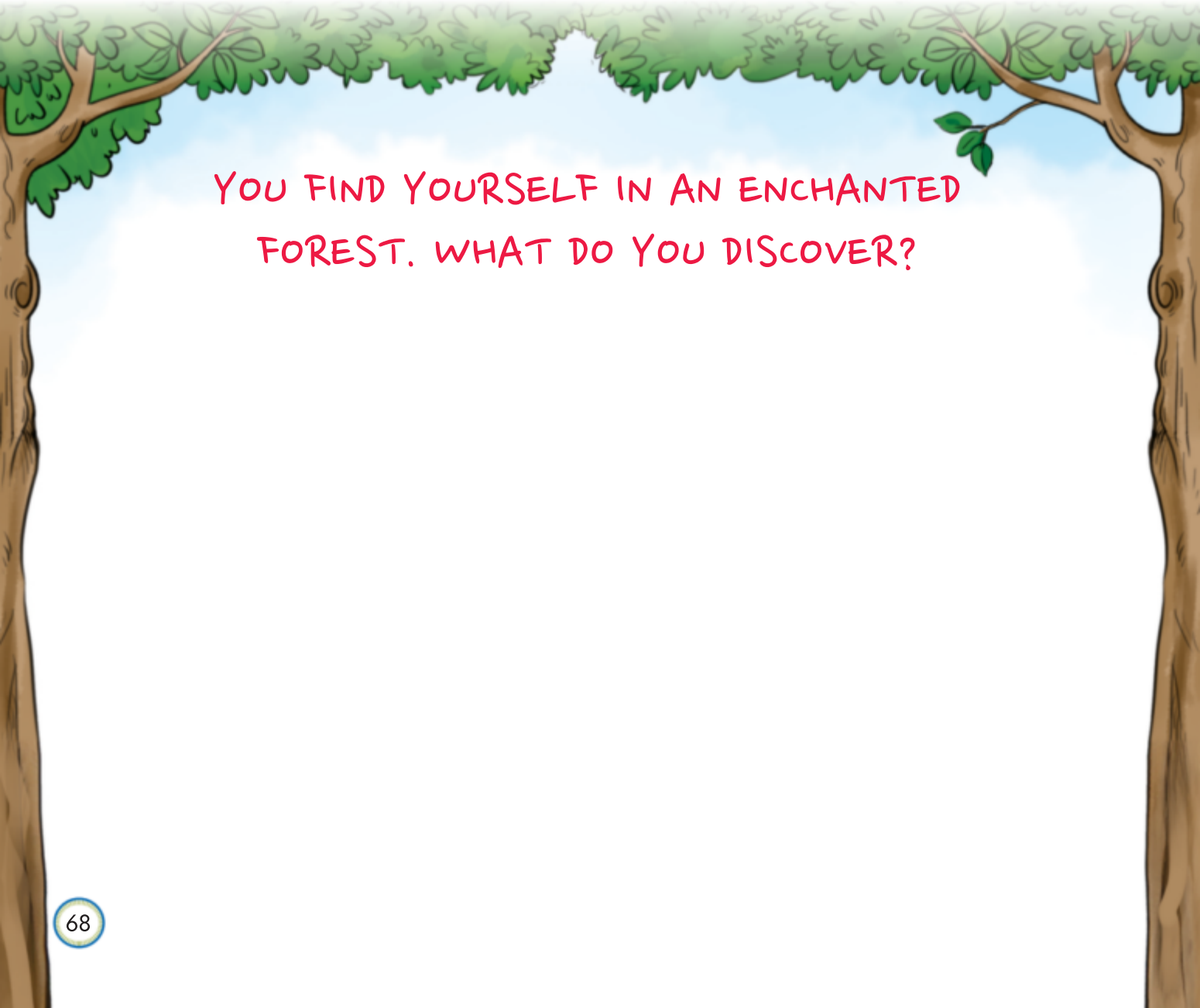
wine	vine	water	vat	wise
vice	wane	vane	win	vim
wick	victory	wiper	viper	waste
vase	waist	visit	will	vile

In this section, we will:
- draw an imaginative picture based on a prompt related to the story.
- write a picture composition expressing our views. (C-3.2, C-3.3)

Write well

Picture prompt

Draw and complete the picture prompt. Then, write a composition describing your enchanted forest and the things you discovered in it.



In this section, we will:
- listen to a story with comprehension and complete its summary.
- play a game to ask and answer questions based on our life experiences.

(C-1.1, C-1.2, C-1.3)

Listen and speak well

1. Just like Mary, the author Frances Hodgson Burnett had a precious friendship with a bird in real life. Listen to the tale about their friendship and fill in the blanks with the appropriate words from the bracket to complete the summary.

In a rose-garden in (a.) _____ (Kent / Yorkshire), the author saw a small bird hopping about in the grass. Using gentle (b.) _____ (pats / sounds), the author attracted the bird by trying to establish a sense of trust and comfort. Each day, the bird grew closer. Eventually, the bird landed on the author's white-coloured hat which had a wreath of (c.) _____ (petunias / roses). As days passed, the bird even perched near the author's (d.) _____ (face / feet) to show its fondness for her.

Before departing from the house, she bid goodbye to the little (e.) _____ (robin / sparrow). She wondered if it would remember her when she returned two to three months later. Upon returning in (f.) _____ (April / March), the author was thrilled to find the bird in the garden. This (g.)_____ (reunion / separation) in the rose garden symbolized the deep bond shared by the author and the (h.) _____ (red-breasted / yellow-breasted) little bird.

2. Let's play a game called 'Have you ever ... ?' Divide yourselves into groups. Each group member will take turns to ask questions to all the other team members, starting with the prompt, "Have you ever ... ?" The question can be related to any unique life experiences. If a group member answers, "Yes, I have", then ask more follow-up questions based on the original prompt to know more about their experience. You may begin with the suggestions given below.

Have you ever befriended a bird?
- What kind of a bird was it?
- How did it respond to your presence?

Have you ever played a musical instrument outdoors?
- What kind of instrument did you play?
- What kind of tune or melody did you play?

Have you ever talked to a gardener?
- What did you talk about?
- How did the conversation help you?

Have you ever saved a plant that was on the verge of drying up?
- What kind of plant was it?
- How did you care for it?

Have you ever seen a nest up close?
- Do you know to which bird the nest belonged?
- What did you observe?

Have you ever secretly made a gift for someone?
- What did you make?
- Was the person surprised?